

The Top 100 Law Reviews: A Reference Guide Based on Historical USNWR Data

Updated February 28, 2026

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A Few Words About Methodology

In 2008, I first compiled a chart that allowed me to order main, or flagship, law reviews based on the rolling averages of historical U.S. News & World Report (USNWR) data. My original impetus for this resource was the sense that whether people like or dislike USNWR's rankings, they are important in shaping many, if not most, law professors' perceptions about the relative strength of a law school (and derivatively, the home law review). That chart, updated with the newest USNWR rankings, begins on page 5 of this document.

Generally speaking, I think the best way of valuing any particular placement is by trying to gauge the value that others would assign to that placement. This is similar to how value is discussed in the real estate market: a house is only worth what someone else is willing to pay for it. When other people think that a law review has cachet or prestige, they will be willing to publish an article with that journal and incur the concomitant opportunity costs. So, for example, the fact that most people would be thrilled to publish an article in Harvard Law Review (HLR)—and almost no one would turn down an offer from HLR—means that an offer from HLR is extremely valuable. The value that others place on HLR is an eminently reasonable basis for you to place value on publishing in HLR.

I believe the best proxy for how other law professors react and respond to publishing in flagship law reviews is the USNWR rankings. These rankings are accessible and widely utilized by prospective students. The fact that prospective students are often fixated on such data means that law professors are also required to pay attention to said data.

That said, in any one year there can be wild swings in USNWR rankings, and those new rankings do not immediately take hold in most law professors' minds. In fact, some may pay no attention to newer rankings, though they likely paid attention to the rankings at some point in their career. Accordingly, I have sorted schools by their 10-year averages because I suspect the majority of current law professors have been active in scholarship at some point during that time period and thus are likely to judge placements based on rankings from that period of time.

A 10-year average is admittedly an exercise in line drawing. The current ranking in any one year seems not useful because only a handful of people will have encoded that ranking in their long-term memory. A 5-year average would be best for capturing the views of scholars who have recently entered the academy. On the other hand, a 15-year average seems to give too short of shrift to the importance of recency in affecting people's cognition. So I view a 10-year rolling average as a "happy medium" in balancing recency with the fact that many of the people whose impressions one might care most about in placing an article have been in the academy for a decade or more. The 5-year and 15-year averages are also included 1) to better discern trends and 2) to have a sense of what more senior and more junior law professors are likely to think of a particular placement.

It is worth noting that U.S. News has made a number of changes to its methodology in recent years, particularly beginning with the 2023–2024 rankings cycle. These changes placed greater emphasis on employment outcomes and bar passage while reducing the weight of admissions metrics such as LSAT and GPA. The shifts in methodology have produced some notable movement within the rankings in the short term. Because the chart below relies on rolling historical averages rather than any single year's ranking, those methodological changes are muted in their effect here.

More broadly, the purpose of this chart is not to defend or critique U.S. News's methodology, which has been the subject of significant debate within legal academia. Rather, the goal is to approximate how law professors tend to perceive the relative prestige of flagship law reviews. To the extent those perceptions are shaped by years of exposure to U.S. News rankings—even as the methodology evolves—historical averages remain a useful proxy for how placement value is commonly understood within the academy.

Frequently Asked Questions

Isn't Washington & Lee's Law Review Rankings (by citation count) a better metric?

In my view, the best metric is the one that most other people use—not necessarily the one that is the most principled, or even defensible. Although I think Washington & Lee does an excellent job of capturing which law reviews are publishing pieces that others cite, I do not think this is how most people judge law reviews.

For example, in the most recent published W&L rankings (2024), Emory LJ is #42, Arizona State LJ is ranked #73, and Texas A&M LR is #135. Ask yourself two questions: (1) Does anyone know these journals' W&L rankings? (2) Is anyone making placement decisions that track with these journals' W&L rankings? Are there 41 journals that are seen as more competitive placements than Emory? Are there 72 better than Arizona State? 134 better than Texas A&M? This might seem like cherry-picking, but the W&L rankings are also peculiar at the top end. E.g., Yale LJ at #4, U. of Chicago LR at #9, and NYU LR at #12. These rankings do not track with how well-published scholars typically make placement decisions.

Isn't US News peer assessment (or "peer rep") a better metric?

Peer rep is a better metric than any one year's current overall ranking, because any changes in peer rep are more glacial and less subject to wild swings. But as I stated above, the metric that makes the most sense for placement decisions is the one that other law professors most frequently use. Here, I believe that more people are aware of a school's USNWR overall rank than their ranking by peer rep. Also, peer rep is derived from USNWR surveys that only allow one to rank any particular school on a 1-5 scale, ranging from "marginal" to "outstanding." In light of this non-granular sorting, one might view peer rep as just as specious as overall USNWR rank. Finally, I have read that, in proverbial tail-wag-dog fashion, overall rank appears to drive peer rep. If that is true, it would be one more reason not to worry much about peer rep.

Isn't Google's Scholar Law Review Rankings a better metric?

Once again, I think the best metric is the one other people most frequently use. I do not think most law professors are knowledgeable of Google Scholar rankings and utilize them for placement decisions.

Wouldn't the best system for ranking law reviews be some combination of USNWR overall ranking, USNWR peer rep, Google Scholar, and/or Washington & Lee?

Maybe. That sounds pretty complicated. In all seriousness, I know that some have put together meta-rankings of this sort, and I have considered doing something similar, but I just don't think many people are familiar enough with Google Scholar or Washington & Lee to justify giving those rankings equal weight to the overall USNWR ranking. For example, when an appointments committee is going through hundreds of FAR forms and trying to quickly gauge each candidate's scholarly potential, I doubt the committee would take the time to consult (or know right off the top of their head) the Google Scholar or Washington & Lee ranking of a particular journal. Similarly, I think that the overall rank of a school should be weighted more heavily than peer rep; again, most people are simply not familiar with peer rep rankings. Finally, I think there is a certain elegance in sorting by just one ranking; a meta-ranking that combines multiple rankings requires even greater defense than one that simply calculates rolling averages of the most familiar and utilized ranking (i.e., USNWR overall).

But don't some schools have better or worse flagship journals than their overall ranking suggests?

Of course. Some schools are known to have better flagship journals than their school's ranking suggests (e.g., Fordham, Illinois, or Cardozo). Conversely, some schools are known to have a better school reputation than flagship journal (I will refrain from supplying examples here). For such journals, one might make a mental adjustment based upon Washington & Lee's citation ranking, USNWR peer rep scores, or one's own individual sense of these things. That said, I think a rolling average of USNWR ranking data is a pretty good proxy for the vast majority of law reviews.

You left off my school – and it is absolutely top 100!

I have worked to include all schools that might have a claim at being "top 100"—hence, my current chart actually includes 105 schools. But I'm far from perfect. If I have omitted any school that has a reasonable claim over a 10-year period to "top 100" status, please email me at brad.areheart@tennessee.edu and I will run the numbers. And if you have data on your school, please send it along. I'd be happy to hear from you!

Were there any ties?

If two law school's 10-year rolling averages were within 1/10 of a point, I tied them and then attempted to break those ties based on the current year's peer reputation scores. You'll see that where there was a tie, I have included the peer rep scores in parentheses for those schools. If the peer rep scores were the same, I allowed the tie to remain.

What about specialty journals?

Admittedly, what I have compiled is not a ranking system for specialty journals. Here, I think Washington & Lee's rankings are one way of roughly comparing a flagship law review to a specialty law review. For example, if you were to receive an offer from the Harvard International Law Journal (HILJ), one way of assessing how that compares to publishing in a flagship journal would be to compare it to the nearest flagship journals in W&L's rankings. In this case, and using W&L's "combined score" rankings from 2024 (the most recent year available), the closest flagship journals to HILJ (#85) are Brooklyn Law Review (#82) and Nevada Law Review (#83). That said, I would like to reiterate that most people are not very familiar with Washington & Lee's rankings.

All of the foregoing leads many—when asked to compare a flagship offer to a specialty offer—to invoke some sort of heuristic such as "add 60" (or "add 50" or "add 70") to the rank of the school at which the specialty is located. Under such a heuristic, one could think of the offer from a

specialty journal at Harvard as roughly equivalent to a flagship journal located around 60. (I.e., adding 60 to Harvard's historical rank of 3 equals 63.)

My own personal view is that the specialty journals at Yale and Harvard enjoy an unusual amount of prestige and thus they ought to be discounted the least. So if one were looking for a rule she might "add 50" for Yale and Harvard specialties and "add 70" for all others. Some will think that is too high of a discount. That is fine; we each have our own opinions. Of course, if you ultimately receive two publication offers (one from a specialty and one from a flagship) that are "close" enough to make you wonder, you should survey those colleagues you know and respect regarding which one they would choose. In practice, I find that people rarely end up with two offers that are so close as to make it a truly hard choice. It's fun to imagine, but usually the choice is clear.

Top 100 Law Schools Based on USNWR Data & Sorted By 10-Year Rolling Averages

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Rank	School	10 Yr	5 Yr	15 Yr	"26	"25	"24	"23	"22	"21	"20	"19	"18	"17	"16	"15	"14	"13	"12
1	Yale	1.0	1.0	1.0	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
2	Stanford	1.8	1.4	2.0	1	1	1	2	2	2	2	2	2	3	2	3	2	2	3
3	Harvard (4.7)	3.6	4.4	3.1	6	4	5	4	3	3	3	3	3	2	2	2	2	3	2
4	Chicago (4.6)	3.6	3.2	3.9	3	3	3	3	4	4	4	4	4	4	4	4	4	5	5
5	Columbia	5.7	6.8	5.1	10	8	8	4	4	4	5	5	5	4	4	4	4	4	4
6	Pennsylvania	6.0	5.0	6.3	5	4	4	6	6	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7	7
7	NYU	6.5	7.0	6.3	8	9	5	7	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6	6
8	Virginia	7.3	6.4	7.5	4	4	8	8	8	8	8	9	8	8	8	8	7	7	9
9	Michigan (4.3)	8.9	9.4	9.1	8	9	10	10	10	9	9	8	8	8	11	10	9	10	7
10	Duke (4.3)	9.0	7.2	9.4	6	4	5	11	10	12	10	11	10	11	8	10	11	11	11
11	Berkeley	10.1	10.6	9.5	13	12	10	9	9	9	10	9	12	8	8	9	9	7	8
12	Northwestern	10.6	10.8	11.1	10	9	10	13	12	9	10	11	10	12	12	12	12	12	12
13	Cornell	13.5	14.0	13.4	18	14	13	12	13	13	13	13	13	13	13	13	13	14	13
14	Georgetown	14.3	14.4	14.1	14	14	15	14	15	14	14	14	15	14	14	13	14	13	14
15	UCLA	14.6	13.6	15.1	12	13	14	15	14	15	15	16	15	17	16	16	17	15	16
16	Texas	15.5	15.8	15.3	14	16	16	17	16	16	16	15	14	15	15	15	15	16	14
17	Vanderbilt	16.8	16.4	16.5	14	19	16	17	16	18	18	17	17	16	17	16	15	16	16
18	Wash. U.	17.1	16.4	17.8	14	16	20	16	16	17	18	18	18	18	18	18	19	23	18
19	USC	19.1	20.2	19.0	26	20	16	20	19	18	17	19	19	17	20	20	18	18	18
20	Minnesota	20.1	19.0	19.9	20	16	16	21	22	21	20	20	23	22	20	20	19	19	20
21	Boston U.	21.8	22.0	23.2	22	24	27	17	20	20	23	22	23	20	26	27	29	26	22
22	Notre Dame	22.3	22.8	22.6	20	20	27	25	22	22	21	24	20	22	22	26	23	22	23
23	Georgia	27.1	23.6	28.9	22	20	20	29	27	31	27	32	30	33	31	29	33	34	35
24	GW	28.3	31.8	25.7	31	41	35	25	27	23	22	24	30	25	22	20	21	20	20
25	Iowa (3.3)	28.5	32.8	27.7	36	36	35	28	29	27	27	27	20	20	22	27	26	29	27
26	Alabama (3.3)	28.6	29.8	27.7	31	33	35	25	25	31	25	27	26	28	22	23	21	29	35
27	Emory (3.6)	29.0	34.8	27.0	38	42	35	30	29	24	26	22	22	22	19	19	23	24	30
28	North Carolina (3.5)	29.0	21.4	30.3	18	20	22	23	24	27	34	45	39	38	34	31	31	38	30
29	Boston College (3.3)	28.9	29.6	29.7	25	28	29	37	29	31	27	27	26	30	34	36	31	29	27
30	Arizona St	29.6	33.6	29.9	45	36	32	30	25	24	27	27	25	25	26	31	29	26	40
31	Ohio State	31.0	29.2	32.3	28	26	22	30	40	38	34	32	30	30	34	31	36	39	35
32	UC Irvine (3.5)	31.4	37.4	31.3	38	42	35	37	35	27	23	21	28	28	30				
33	Florida (3.4)	31.5	26.0	36.8	38	28	22	21	21	24	31	41	41	48	47	49	46	48	47
34	Wake Forest (3.2)	33.2	30.2	34.7	26	25	22	37	41	42	31	32	36	40	47	31	36	44	31
35	BYU (3.0)	33.1	26.0	35.1	28	28	22	23	29	37	39	41	46	38	34	36	44	39	42
36	Wisconsin (3.5)	33.8	35.2	33.5	28	36	40	43	29	38	34	27	30	33	31	31	33	35	35
37	Wash & Lee (3.2)	33.8	35.8	33.5	36	33	40	35	35	31	34	26	28	40	42	43	26	24	30
38	Fordham	34.8	34.4	34.3	38	33	29	37	35	27	39	37	36	37	34	36	38	29	30
39	Wm & Mary	35.8	35.4	33.7	31	36	45	30	35	31	39	37	41	33	29	24	33	35	27
40	George Mason	37.6	32.4	38.9	31	28	32	30	41	42	45	41	41	45	42	46	41	39	40
41	Indiana - Bloom.	37.8	43.8	34.3	46	42	45	43	43	38	34	32	30	25	33	29	25	26	23
42	Illinois	38.2	38.2	37.9	48	36	43	35	29	31	39	37	44	40	41	40	47	35	23
43	UtahB47	40.6	34.2	41.8	31	28	32	37	43	45	47	54	44	45	42	49	41	47	42
44	UC Davis	41.2	47.4	37.9	50	55	60	37	35	38	31	37	39	30	31	36	38	29	23
45	U. Wash. (WA)	42.2	48.2	36.8	50	48	49	49	45	42	44	32	30	33	28	24	28	20	30
46	Colorado	46.0	49.4	45.2	46	48	56	49	48	46	45	46	36	40	40	43	44	44	47
47	Arizona	47.4	51.8	45.3	59	55	54	45	46	47	39	41	48	40	42	40	38	43	42
48	Florida State U.	48.0	47.4	48.3	38	48	56	47	48	50	48	47	48	50	50	45	48	51	50

49	SMU	48.9	48.0	48.4	43	42	45	58	52	56	52	50	46	45	46	42	48	51	50
50	Baylor U.	50.8	50.8	51.7	43	46	49	58	58	50	48	50	51	55	56	51	54	51	56
51	Maryland	51.0	53.2	48.3	63	55	51	47	50	47	52	49	48	48	47	46	41	39	42
52	Temple U.	52.8	54.8	54.4	50	54	54	63	53	56	48	47	53	50	52	61	56	58	61
53	Pepperdine	53.9	50.0	53.9	55	52	45	52	46	47	51	65*	72	65	52	54	61	49	54
54	Connecticut	56.9	59.6	57.5	50	55	71	64	58	50	52	50	54	65	63	54	58	62	56
55	Richmond	57.0	60.4	56.7	71	66	60	52	53	54	52	50	57	55	52	51	53	58	67
56	Houston	58.4	61.8	57.5	63	68	60	58	60	56	59	56	54	50	59	58	48	57	56
57	Tulane (3.1)	58.9	67.0	55.4	71	78	71	55	60	54	52	47	51	50	50	46	48	51	47
58	Tennessee (2.8)	59.0	54.8	60.0	55	52	51	56	60	70	59	65	57	65	52	72	61	69	56
59	Cardozo (2.9)	59.8	59.6	60.1	63	61	69	52	53	53	52	56	65	74	75	64	58	56	50
60	Villanova (2.8)	59.7	49.6	70.7	48	48	43	56	53	62	71	65	77	74	87	93	98	101	84
61	Texas A&M	60.3	35.2	60.3	22	26	29	46	53	60	83	80	92	112					
62	UC-San Fran. (3.1)	61.4	66.2	57.4	88	82	60	51	50	59	62	58	54	50	59	54	48	44	42
63	Kansas (2.8)	61.4	54.6	66.9	50	46	40	67	70	70	67	74	65	65	67	68	86	89	79
64	Seton Hall	63.3	66.2	63.9	71	61	56	73	70	62	59	59	57	65	63	68	64	69	61
65	Missouri	64.2	63.2	68.3	57	61	71	67	60	67	64	65	65	65	59	64	76	76	107
66	Loyola, L.A.	65.0	66.2	65.7	71	61	60	67	72	62	62	65	65	65	75	87	68	51	54
67	Kentucky	66.0	67.4	64.8	68	61	60	67	81	70	71	65	57	60	63	58	58	62	71
68	Oklahoma	66.2	64.0	67.2	59	55	51	88	67	76	71	63	72	60	67	58	68	82	71
69	Penn St - Dick.	68.4	68.2	67.1	59	75	89	58	60	62	71	59	65	86	71	51	64	76	60
70	UNLV	69.2	74.6	70.5	79	78	89	67	60	62	58	59	62	78	67	83	68	76	71
71	Northeastern	69.9	69.4	74.1	68	68	71	73	67	67	64	74	65	82	87	93	86	76	71
72	Penn St - U. Park	70.6	68.0	68.5	68	68	80	64	60	60	64	74	82	86	71	51	64	76	60
73	Georgia St.	70.9	75.8	66.8	79	75	69	78	78	76	67	65	65	57	56	64	54	58	61
74	Miami (2.8)	72.6	78.0	71.5	92	82	71	73	72	67	67	65	77	60	63	61	76	69	77
75	St. John's U. (2.4)	72.7	69.4	79.0	63	68	60	84	72	74	77	83	72	74	82	107	98	76	95
76	Nebraska	75.4	81.4	73.2	71	82	89	78	87	76	77	80	57	57	56	54	61	89	84
77	Case West.	75.7	85.2	71.7	107	89	80	78	72	76	71	65	62	57	59	64	68	67	61
78	Denver (2.9)	76.5	82.6	74.0	88	89	80	78	78	74	67	63	76	72	67	68	64	69	77
79	Cincinnati (2.3)	76.5	80.4	75.7	71	78	84	88	81	83	83	65	72	60	82	79	80	69	61
80	San Diego (3.0)	76.8	70.6	74.5	57	68	78	64	86	83	86	95	77	74	71	79	68	65	67
81	Loyola - Chicago (2)	76.7	78.4	75.1	79	78	84	73	78	70	77	74	82	72	78	68	76	67	71
82	Wayne St.	78.1	62.4	87.3	71	55	56	58	72	83	91	98	100	97	105	87	105	110	121
83	Pittsburgh	79.1	80.8	78.7	79	91	89	78	67	76	77	74	82	78	78	81	91	69	71
84	Oregon	81.3	78.6	83.3	94	82	78	67	72	88	83	85	86	78	82	100	94	82	79
85	S. Carolina	82.4	73.8	88.1	63	66	60	84	96	96	91	88	88	92	93	93	98	109	104
86	American	84.2	89.0	76.0	104	98	89	73	81	76	77	80	86	78	71	72	56	49	50
87	Rutgers	87.4	98.6	87.6	104	103	109	86	91	76	77	74	62	92	94.5	82	88.5	90.5	84
88	Florida Int'l	88.3	79.6	90.6	84	68	60	98	88	90	91	101	100	103	102	45	105	113	111
89	St. Louis U. (2.5)	90.4	93.2	92.7	94	94	89	98	91	90	90	88	88	82	87	93	102	101	104
90	New Mex. (2.4)	90.5	98.0	84.0	107	94	96	91	102	99	91	88	77	60	71	72	64	69	79
91	Marquette	91.6	81.0	93.3	59	68	71	105	102	102	91	95	100	123	105	93	94	96	95
92	Lewis & Clark	92.5	88.2	86.4	99	82	84	88	88	93	104	95	100	92	94	72	80	58	67
93	Chicago-Kent	93.2	99.8	84.9	107	108	99	94	91	83	87	85	92	86	78	72	68	62	61
94	Brooklyn	94.3	104.2	87.7	117	114	111	98	81	83	71	83	88	97	78	83	80	65	67
95	Arkansas - Fay.	94.8	103.2	88.3	115	114	105	86	96	90	91	88	77	86	75	61	68	89	84
96	LSU	95.0	97.6	90.1	84	91	99	105	109	96	100	88	96	82	94	72	76	76	84
97	New Hamp.	96.2	104.2	103.1	125	98	105	105	88	87	87	85	100	82	87	93	119	142	143
98	Mich. St.	98.4	103.2	94.8	115	108	111	91	91	93	91	88	96	100	94	87	80	82	95
99	Syracuse	102.2	110.8	100.5	107	120	122	103	102	111	91	88	92	86	87	107	96	96	100
100	Hawaii (2.6)	103.0	110.0	99.5	99	127	135	91	98	96	91	101	100	92	82	100	80	106	95

101	Indiana - Ind. (2.5)	102.9	102.6	98.9	107	98	99	98	111	122	108	98	88	100	102	87	98	89	79
102	Buffalo-SUNY	103.4	103.8	98.2	94	108	125	94	98	99	104	106	106	100	87	100	86	82	84
103	Tulsa	105.4	117.4	100.1	127	120	111	118	111	111	87	101	82	86	82	72	86	99	109
104	Louisville	107.7	114.6	101.0	146	136	99	94	98	99	108	113	92	92	94	87	68	89	100
105	W. Virginia	108.9	115.8	103.5	117	117	111	118	116	111	100	106	96	97	94	83	91	101	95
Rank	School	10 Yr	5 Yr	15 Yr	"26	"25	"24	"23	"22	"21	"20	"19	"18	"17	"16	"15	"14	"13	"12

Please reach out! Send comments, corrections, or questions to brad.areheart@tennessee.edu.